



Best bet: Romario Shepherd is West Indies' clearest match-winner in a side still searching for cohesion. GETTYIMAGES

2025, the pair has scored at 11.39 per over in the first six overs, outdoing even India and Australia, who started this trend of throwing caution to the wind in the PowerPlay.

Jacob Bethell and Brook bring a similar template through the middle order, along with Tom Banton, who has found a new lease of life by embracing a role outside the top order.

Such has been the effect of England's refurbishing that Ben Duckett, despite his flair for the audacious, might not find a place in the batting order.

Sam Curran's vast experience in the subcontinent through the Indian Premier League will be priceless for England. Will Jacks can chip in with his off-spin, too, once pitches wear out with time, and is likely to be the second all-rounder in the side.

Veteran leg-spinner Adil Rashid, who will most probably take his final bow at this World Cup, is still England's most prolific bowler. He has nabbed 23 wickets since the last World Cup at an economy of just

8.47. England has also slated Rehan Ahmed, who might still struggle to break in if the side manages to get the best out of Bethell's part-time left-arm orthodox.

Liam Dawson, Josh Tongue, Jamie Overton and Luke Wood are contenders for the two places in the three-man pace attack that will be spearheaded by Jofra Archer.

Dodgy build-up

The outlook is not as promising for the Caribbean outfit, the other heavyweight in the group. Only one team has fared worse than the West Indies in this World Cup cycle, with the side winning just 13 of its 40 games since July 2024.

A team fractured by players' franchise commitments, the current group has yet to live up to the reputation that comes with the West Indies name. Captain Shai Hope and key members Akeal Hosein, Sherfane Rutherford and Roston Chase all

missed the side's preparatory series against Afghanistan due to the SA20.

The final series before the World Cup, against South Africa, was then reduced to just three games because of time constraints.

Romario Shepherd is the undisputed match-winner in the squad and has contributed with both bat and ball, collecting 35 wickets and scoring 442 runs in this World Cup cycle. West Indies can also rely on Hosein, whose inventive change-ups have been a revelation for slow left-arm orthodox bowling. Mixing his pace and trajectory effectively, Hosein has taken 35 wickets since July 2024 at an economy rate under seven.

These silver linings, however, do not outweigh the broader problems. The rest of the lineup, particularly the batting, has significant ground to cover if West Indies is to be a genuine contender for the Super

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